

fridayReview

THE HINDU

Conservation of temples
Inscriptions reveal how they were built, repaired and preserved over centuries **p2**

More than just music
Singer Dhammarakshit presents songs that challenge social inequality **p3**



**UTSAV LAL
BACK ON AN
INDIA TOUR**

The pianist will present his famed Ragas to Reels project in four cities **p4**

R. Revathi

Krishna nee begane baro... Few devotional songs evoke a sense of warmth and tenderness quite like this timeless Dasara pada by Vyasaraya. Set in Yamuna Kalyani, this devaranama is often presented in the latter half of music concerts. It is also a favourite among Bharatanatyam dancers. For dancers, the song opens up an entire world of creative possibilities, taking them through Krishna's playful childhood to the moment when he reveals the universe within his little mouth to his astonished mother Yashoda.

Krishna appears in different forms and moods in the devaranamas of the Haridasas. He is the mischievous child who steals butter, the charming Gopala of Brindavan, the divine protector and the supreme being to whom the devotees turn to with love and complete surrender.

The Haridasa movement enriched Kannada devotional literature with a vast and enduring body of compositions known as devaranamas. The followers of Madhvacharya propagated their beliefs through songs that made profound spiritual concepts accessible to people. Vishnu and his various manifestations, such as Krishna, Keshava, Rama and Venkateshwara were the central focus of these keerthanas, though there were also songs dedicated to other deities.

Sripadaraja is often regarded as the father of the Haridasa tradition. He helped shape the movement by expressing complex philosophical ideas in simple Kannada. His disciple Vyasaraya gave further impetus to it, while Purandaradasa and Kanakadasa carried its message to a wider audience through their compositions. Together, Vadiraja, Sripadaraja and Vyasaraya are known as the Yati Trayaru, the three saint-scholars of this tradition.

The Haridasas belonged to the regions that are now part of Karnataka. The movement flourished during the Vijayanagara Empire. Hampi, with its Vittala temple on the banks of the Tungabhadra, is closely connected with this tradition. Purandaradasa is believed to have sung songs at a mantapa near the temple. Vittala, whether in Pandharpur or in Hampi, embodied the divine for the Haridasas and many composers used Vittala as their *ankita* or *udra* of their compositions.

Purandaradasa, who used the mudra 'Purandara Vittala' occupies a special place among the Haridasas. His padas on

Krishna calling

On Janmashtami, revisiting the myriad forms of Krishna as envisioned in Dasa verse



Krishna occupy a prominent place in the Carnatic repertoire. 'Jagadodharana,' a portrayal of toddler Krishna of Doddamalluru, remains one of the most beloved devaranamas. 'Narayana ninna namada,' usually sung in Suddha Dhanyasi, offers immense scope for musical elaboration, especially in the charanam lines. 'Krishna krishna endu.' 'Tharakka bindige,' often sung in Tilang, holds a profound spiritual

In poetic hues, an Illustration by Keshav.V A carving of Purandaradasa on one of the pillars at the Purandara Mantapa in Hampi. PHOTO: SPECIAL ARRANGEMENT

'Odi barayya' in Bhairavi and 'Pogadirelo ranga' in Sankarabharanam, often feature as main pieces in kutcheris. There are also many beautiful padas that are not heard much in concerts, such as 'Hannu thaa benne thaa' and 'Thoogidale rangana yashode' in Nilambari that bring the world of Yashoda and her little Krishna alive.

If Purandaradasa's Krishna appears in familiar forms, Kanakadasa's compositions reflect a personal bond with the deity, particularly Udupi Krishna. It is said that he was denied entry into the temple. So, he stood outside and pleaded 'Bagilanu teredu seveyanu kodu Hariye' (Open the door, O! Hari and let me see you.) According to the legend, Krishna turned towards him and offered him darshan through a small opening in the temple wall. The *Kanakana Kindi* (Kanakadasa's window), through which devotees continue to view Udupi Krishna stands as a reminder of that moment. Before becoming a Haridasa, Kanakadasa was a warrior, which lends a distinct voice to his works. He used 'Kagineleya adikeslava' or simply 'Adikeslava' as the signature in his compositions.

Among Kanakadasa's best-known compositions are the ragamalikas 'Baro krishnayya' and 'Yadavaraya brindavanadolu', both of which are widely performed.

The world of Dasara padas goes beyond these two great names. Padas such as 'Baro namma manege Gopalakrishna' by Sreepada Rajaru set in Vasantha, 'Bega

baro bega baro neela megha varna' by Vadiraja in Maand, 'Ranga banda brindavanadalininda' by Vyasaraya in Brindavana Saranga and 'Sada enna hrudayadalli' by Vijaya Vittaladasa in Behag continue to be sung in concerts.

'Kandu dhanyanade udupi krishna' in Behag by Kamalesha Vittala Dasaru has been popularised by stalwarts such as D.K. Pattammal and



K.V. Narayanaswamy. Another well-known composition on Krishna is 'Chandadinda banda node' by Vasudeva Vittala, which is often rendered in a folk style or as a bhajan.

The musical journey of these compositions owes much to musicians who took it to wider audiences. M.L. Vasanthakumari played a pioneering role in bringing Dasara padas to the Carnatic concert stage. Artistes from Karnataka, including Vidyabhushana, M.S. Sheela, R.K. Padmanabha, Puttur Narasimha Nayak and Neela Ramgopal are among the

many musicians who made these a staple at their concerts. These padas found their way into Hindustani music too. The legendary Bhimsen Joshi stands out for including pieces such as 'Yadava nee baa' and 'Neenyako ninna hangyako' in his repertoire.

The Haridasa tradition also includes ugabhogas, which are free-flowing, lyrical expressions that are not structured into the conventional pallavi, anupallavi and charanam format. They are rendered similarly to a virutham and often precede a devaranama. 'Aaneyu karedare', a popular ugabhoga, is often sung in Sivaranjani, while 'Ninnantha swami enaguntu ninagilla' is frequently heard as a ragamalika.

M.L. Vasanthakumari would often sing the ugabhoga 'Tamburi meettidava' before 'Narayana ninna namada' in Suddha Dhanyasi. The duo Radha-Jayalakshmi sang the ugabhoga 'Elutha govindage' as a prelude to the same devaranama, although it is also presented as an independent piece. Young musicians today are also exploring ugabhogas by setting them to different ragas.

Perhaps that is why Krishna lives on in the verses of the Haridasas. One moment he is the mischievous child, the next the enchanter of the gopis, and then the divine charioteer imparting the wisdom of the *Gita*. Yet, for all his myriad forms, he remains close enough for a devotee to call out to him with love and longing: 'Krishna nee begane baro.'

CULTUREBRIEFS



Insights on Dikshitar

The Music Academy in collaboration with Prakriti Foundation will launch *Singing the Wind (Four essays on Muthuswami Dikshitar)* by noted Indologist David Shulman. The event will be held on September 6, 10.30 a.m., at the Kasturi Srinivasan Hall. David Shulman will deliver a lecture, followed by Sikkil Gurucharan's concert. He will be accompanied by

Gayatri Shivani (violin) and Adharsh Devarajan (mridangam). Marking the 250th birth anniversary of Dikshitar, the book explores the music, structure and cultural background of four compositions — Abhayamba vibhakti kriti, Sri Kalahastisa, Akshayalinga Vibho and Sri Rajagopala. Shulman offers his personal interpretations of these pieces.



Celebrating a guru

Guru Kaaraikkudi Mani's Sruthi Laya Kendra in association with Narada Gana Sabha presents a musical tribute to the mridangam maestro on the occasion of his 81st birth anniversary on September 11. The event will begin with the presentation of 'Guru Kaaraikkudi Mani Award' for excellence in percussion to chenda maestro Mattanur Sankarankutty Marar at 5.45 p.m., the evening will feature Sandeep Narayan's vocal concert. He will be accompanied by L. Ramakrishnan on the violin, Sumesh

Narayan on the mridangam and S. Krishna on the ghatam. Kaaraikkudi Mani was known for pushing the boundaries of rhythm through bold experimentations even while preserving its traditional essence. His distinctive style and innovative tala patterns continues to inspire young percussionists. Through his performances, teaching and collaborations, he has left behind an enduring legacy.

May Lord Sri Krishna's divine grace fill every home with happiness, harmony and prosperity.



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Etched on stone
(Clockwise from left)
Thanjavur Big temple;
inscriptions seen on one of
its walls; and an image of
the sculptor alongside an
engraved measuring scale
once seen at a temple
mandapam in Madurai.
PHOTOS: R. VENGADESH; B.
VELANKANNI RAJ & K. SRIDHARAN

The conservation story

Tamil Nadu's temple inscriptions reveal how structures were built, repaired and preserved over centuries

Suganthy Krishnamachari

Tamil Nadu's rich epigraphical wealth demonstrates how ancient temple inscriptions serve as definitive blueprints for heritage conservation and restoration. During a lecture, hosted recently by the Tamil Nadu Archaeology Department, at the Tamil Virtual Academy, K. Sridharan, former deputy superintending archaeologist, shed light on what these stone records reveal about the preservation and renovation of sacred structures.

The Chola dynasty actively preserved sacred architecture by converting vulnerable brick temples into permanent stone structures, known as *katrali*. The dowager queen Sembian Madevi was responsible for many such temples. However, conservation was not the exclusive domain of royalty; even ordinary people actively participated in such efforts. For example, an inscription at the Adavalleswarar temple in Thalaiyalangadu reveals that an individual named Kalingaraja independently undertook the reconstruction of the original brick temple into a *katrali*.

Sometimes, conservation was a joint effort of the local community, an example of what might be described as crowdfunding in the past.

At the Vadakadu Koyilur Mantirapureeswarar temple, an inscription records that local residents pledged a fixed portion of their agricultural income for repairs. The inscriptions at the Thenkarai Moolanathaswamy temple even record the names individual contributors alongside the exact extent of their donations. One such was Kalaiya Mangalamudaiyaan Sootri Udhaiyan, who funded the repair of a single *muzham*. However, structural changes required prior approval. An inscription in the Thiruvaijavur temple substantiates this point: It notes that royal permission had to be obtained before converting a brick temple into a *katrali*.

The rulers exhibited humility and generosity in their approach to construction and conservation work. Parakrama Pandya (1423-1463 CE), who initiated the construction of the Tenkasi Kasi Viswanatha temple, which was completed later by his younger brother, left a poignant inscription displaying humility. He declared, *Thenkasi aalayam deiva cheyalaale samaindadu; yen cheyal alla* (the Thenkasi temple was created by divine intervention; it is not my doing). The king concluded with a direct appeal to future generations, imploring them to repair any structural damage the temple might face over time.

Temple construction involved technocrats, who had varied skills. For



example, the *sutragrahi* took measurements; a *thachan* was a stonecutter or carpenter; the *vardhaki*, an expert in intricate joinery, brought the physical structure together and the *sthapathy* was the chief architect. Many artisans also left their marks on history. Inscribed on a rock on the way to Mamallapuram from Thirukazhukkundram are names such as Kevatha Perunthachan. They were, perhaps, sculptors who worked in Mamallapuram. Sometimes, we also find images of the sculptors, besides the names, left behind, like the one in Konerirajapuram. The Konerirajapuram sculptor

was honoured with the title 'Raja Kesari Moovenda Velaan'.

Stone records were also kept of architectural additions. An inscription belonging to the regnal year of Rajendra Chola I, seen at the Thiruvottriyur temple, notes that an architect named Veera Chola Thachan used black stone to construct a decorative, three-tiered *vimanam*.

There are records to highlight how the artisans used different regional variants of the measuring scale: Thanjavur *muzham* (2 ft 9 inches), Chidambaram *muzham* (2 ft 10 inches) and Madurai *muzham* (2 ft 8 inches). Standardised scales were carved in quite a few temples. The Ulagalanda Perumal temple in Kanchipuram features an engraved 32-inch *thachumuzham* with vertical markings at intervals of 1, 8, 16, and 24 inches. A similar scale is engraved at the Kanchi Varadarajar temple.

Restoration methods

To ensure long-term preservation, kings established permanent land endowments for future repairs, designated as Thiruppanipuram or Pudukkuppuram (as recorded in a Tiruvarur inscription). While some restorations utilised stone, an inscription at the Thirupputalur temple indicates that repairs there were carried out using *ittikai* (bricks). An Achuthamangalam inscription mentions the appointment of a Thiruppani Kankaani – a

dedicated officer tasked with supervising repair works.

Ancient builders approached structural restoration with forensic precision. A 15th-century inscription details the comprehensive restoration of the 12th-century Bhoolokanatha Swamy temple in Thirumangalam, near Mayiladuthurai. Every part of the temple was systematically labelled, and each stone was numbered. Door frames were distinctly marked 'South' and 'North,' while structural beams were catalogued as either *akavanai* (interior) or *puravanai* (exterior) to ensure accurate reassembly.

Ancient conservators treated original historical records with the same reverence as the physical architecture. When Queen Sembian Madevi renovated the Thirukkodikaval temple, she ordered all pre-existing inscriptions to be carefully re-engraved, adding the words *idhuvum oru pazhankarpadi* (this too is an old inscription). Similarly, when a portion of a stone bearing a Rajadhi Raja inscription was damaged at the Jwarahareshwara temple in Melapathi, it was replaced in the 16th century. The newly carved stone had the phrase *kal azhivu* (stone damaged).

Beyond lithic records, a specialised genre of literature known as *Thiruppani Maalai* preserves the technical details of past restoration works. The *Madurai Thiruppani Maalai*, for instance, describes an expensive (*vegu rokkam kuduthu*) restoration project at the Meenakshi Amman temple. It documents the scientific methods of ancient construction and preservation, and records the replacement of pillars and beams. Bricks were laid using a mortar made of slaked lime mixed with a cocktail of fermented *kadukkai* (myrobalan), jaggery, and gooseberry.

Collectively, these epigraphical records prove that ancient Tamil Nadu possessed a highly organised, sophisticated and deeply reverent culture of heritage conservation.

A march through history

Komal Theatre's *Endru Thaniyum* chronicles landmark episodes of India's freedom struggle

V.V. Ramani

Komal Theatres' *Endru Thaniyum*, offered a theatrical re-look at the episodes that eventually led to India's Independence. In an attempt to traverse this vast historical journey within a span of two hours, the production brought together familiar milestones and lesser-known episodes to offer a visual account of India's journey to freedom.

The story begins with William Hawkins landing at Surat in 1608 aboard the ship called Hector, carrying a letter from King James I of England seeking permission to establish a trading port in Surat. This initial move paved the way for the East India Company's entry into India, and eventually, expanding its control over the country. The Company's journey from being traders to rulers, the varied revolts during the freedom struggle movement and the political developments that culminated in India's Independence formed the storyline of *Endru Thaniyum*.

The production was staged to commemorate 150 years of 'Vande Mataram'. Scripted and directed by Dharini Komal, it had historical inputs from Satish Kumar, music by Rajkumar Bharathi and voice over by Ilango Kumanan.

Compressing a vast sweep of history into a two-hour play is no easy feat, yet, Dharini Komal managed to highlight most of the significant episodes. The sequences unfolded in the form of a conversation between a grandfather and his grandson, although the latter appeared only twice.

The initial scenes, depicting William Hawkins' arrival at Surat and his meeting with Emperor Jahangir, began on a stilted note. Jahangir's glittering costume and make-up appeared garish, while the performance was weighed down by self-conscious acting. The play gradually gathered momentum and began to find its rhythm with the powerfully

enacted scenes depicting Velu Nachiar and the Marudu brothers, planning their attack on the British.

One of the play's strengths was its attempt to place well-known episodes such as the revolt of Rani Laxmi Bai of Jhansi, against the British rule, alongside the story of Vanchinathan and his assassination of the district collector of Tirunelveli, Robert Ashe, at Maniyachi Railway station. The production carefully chronicled these events through swift scene changes. The Swadeshi movement, the Dandi March, the Jallianwala Bagh massacre, the formation of the Indian National Congress, Jinnah's call for Partition and the events leading to Independence on August 15, 1947, were among the other landmark events woven into the narrative seamlessly. The subsequent scenes covered many historical episodes without lingering too long on any one event.

Care has been taken in casting actors for iconic characters such as Mahatma Gandhi, Jawaharlal Nehru, Sardar Vallabhai Patel, Gopal Krishna Gokhale, Bhagat Singh and Rani Laxmi Bai, and they depicted the roles with conviction. However, the affected English accents adopted by those playing the British at times came across as artificial.

The LED and AI projections, designed by Kannan Ruthrapathy, stood out. Created with attention to detail, they convincingly captured the milieu of each episode. The lighting design by Biju Kumar, which was handled by Cheta Ravi, complemented the projections thus enhancing the visual appeal of the production.

While the production accommodated a range of events with conviction, the overall impact was more like attending a visual history lesson than a theatrical narrative. Though the audience was able to understand the significance of the incidents being portrayed, the play did not succeed in evoking the emotional resonance it appeared to aim for.



A slice of the past A scene from *Endru Thaniyum*.
PHOTO: M. SRINATH

When four's company

A concert by Shreya Devnath, Mylai Karthikeyan, Praveen Sparsh and G. Silambarasan balanced a classical repertoire with diverse musical influences

R. Revathi

A Carnatic quartet comprising violinist Shreya Devnath, nagaswaram artiste Mylai Karthikeyan, and percussionists Praveen Sparsh on the mridangam and G. Silambarasan on the thavil, presented a carefully structured concert at Unnati's Gokulashtami music series. The performance struck a fine

balance between traditional repertoire and thoughtfully chosen compositions from beyond it.

The concert opened in the style of a temple nagaswaram recital with thavil setting the pace before Mylai Karthikeyan entered with Gambhira Nattai. The mridangam and violin joined in subsequently, leading into a Mallari composed by Karthikeyan, set to Sankeerna jati Triputa tala. The opening had the energy of a temple



procession, while the four instruments lent it a concert setting.

The kriti 'Ganamurte' by Tyagaraja in Ganamurti was followed by a short raga prelude. It was presented in a gait that could make effective use of sarvalaghu patterns in the kalpanaswara passages. Another Tyagaraja composition, 'Hechcharikaga ra ra' came after an outline of Yadukulakamboji. The presentation of this kriti, set to Khanda Chapu in a comfortable chowka kala,

allowed the rhythmic syllables to come through – without being hurried.

Behag brought a change in mood. A short raga alapana led to a brief tanam with the mridangam joining in. Swati Tirunal's 'Smara janaka subha charita' was rendered without any swara section.

The Bhairavi alapana was the expansive part of the concert. Shreya began the raga on the violin with Karthikeyan taking it forward on the nagaswaram. The two approaches to the raga

complemented each other with the nagaswaram adding a different breadth to the phrases. Muthuswami Dikshitar's 'Bala gopala' was the main kriti of the evening.

The swarakalpana, around the madhyama kala line beginning with 'Drona karna', was particularly interesting. Shreya shared that she had learnt the pattern from her guru Lalgudi Jayaraman when the maestro played a recording of his own rendition and explained the conception too. The pattern, built around the

abhang 'Ba re Panduranga' in Maand was followed by 'Amar mallika bone', a Rabindra Sangeet piece – adding variety to the line-up.

The familiar 'Krishna nee begane baro' by Vyasaraya in Yamunakalyani returned the focus to the Gokulashtami theme after the main kriti. Muthuswami Dikshitar's nottuswaram, 'Rama janardhana' was played in two kalams, its Western-tinged lines blended smoothly with the composition. The concert concluded with Lalgudi Jayaraman's Madhuvanti thillana and the traditional mangalam.

The understanding among the musicians and the sensitivity with which each performed helped retain the characteristic vibrance of nagaswaram and thavil as well as the melodic familiarity of violin and mridangam. The concert brought together different musical explorations without making the contrasts feel forced.

Teamwork The musicians at Unnati's Gokulashtami music series.
PHOTO: SPECIAL ARRANGEMENT

sequence 'ri sa ni dha pa ma ga ri', was presented as an imagery of arrows released from a bow and reaching their intended targets, suiting the lyrics 'Drona karna', denoting the Mahabharata war. The quartet recreated this pattern with seamless coordination between the swaras and Adi tala in two kalai.

The tani avartanam was more vibrant compared to the relatively smooth accompaniment during the kritis, creating a distinct contrast. The violin and nagaswaram joined in for the concluding part of mohra – built in the same pattern rendered during the kalpanaswara part – making the concept enjoyable.

From here, the concert moved on to a broadened repertoire. Sant Tukaram's

Singer and activist Dhammarakshit draws on centuries-old poetry to spark conversations on social injustice

Shailaja Tripathi

It poured that evening. On the first floor of the Mandiram, Raghav Shreyas Foundation for Arts in Basavanagudi, rain hammered the old Mangalore-tiled roof. Inside, a small gathering sat huddled in the cosy room. The old house, with its unmistakable Bangalore character, had no conventional stage or fancy lighting. There was just an artiste, his voice, and a room full of people listening. For Dhammarakshit, this intimate setting was something of an experiment. The Mumbai-based Ambedkarite lok shahir is accustomed to performing with a group of 10-15 singers in the energetic, collective format of shahiri jalsa. This solo concert, revolving around the poetry of the ‘Sathyasodhak’ (truth-seekers), was quieter and more reflective. It also required him to step outside a form he is most comfortable with. He began with voices that have travelled across centuries: Ravidas, Kabir, Chokhamela, Soyra Bai, Tukaram and Mahatma Jyotiba



Phule. The songs questioned caste, hierarchy, ritual and the ownership of knowledge. Kabir’s “Nirbhay nirgun gun re” sat naturally alongside the words of saints whose spiritual search was intertwined with their struggle against social injustice. For Dhammarakshit, these are not simply bhakti poets. He sees them as part of a longer mukti (liberation) movement tradition, a lineage of people who challenged the social order of their time. Among them was Soyra Bai, the 14th-century Mahar saint-poet and wife of saint Chokhamela. The couple was denied entry into the temple because of their caste. Yet Soyra Bai’s poetry went far beyond devotional expression. In *Vitaal*, she writes, ‘Dehasi vitala mhanti sakal, Atma to nirmal shuddha-buddha’



Radical notes Dhammarakshit; and with the Yalgaar Sanskrutik Manch, founded by him as a cultural movement for human liberation. PHOTOS: SPECIAL ARRANGEMENT

questioning the idea of ritual impurity attached to menstruation. She observes that the body is considered impure while the soul remains pure. Her best-known abhang, ‘Avagha rang ek zala’, has entered the classical music world through the renditions of artistes such as Kishori Amonkar, but Dhammarakshit points out that the radicality of Soyra Bai and other saint-poets remains relatively unknown. He says what survives as a beautiful song and what gets lost from the original thought is something he is interested in investigating. Dhammarakshit grew up in Satara as son of a Lok Shahiri (folk singer). His earliest musical memories came from his father, who sang Ambedkarite songs and patriotic compositions. His understanding of music as a means for social questioning developed later, through his association with the Muktivadi Sangathan in Satara. Study circles, film screenings and readings deepened his thinking around caste, class, religion and gender. He began his activist work around 2008. In 2014, a group of artistes, activist-friends and he founded Yalgaar Sanskrutik Manch as an “alternative cultural movement for human liberation”. Its work has taken shahiri, theatre and music into streets, communities and mainstream cultural spaces. Lok shahiri itself has an interesting history. Emerging from traditions of travelling and marginalised singer-poets who performed at festivals, fairs and even upper-caste celebrations, it gradually became a powerful tool for Dalit expression and protest. Its strength lies partly in its topicality, as it responds to the prevailing situations in society and country. It’s never a solo performance, which is why Dhammarakshit had reservations about this performance in Bengaluru, his first solo. A number of singers and musicians come together to share a stage. The artiste-activist says that the form flourishes particularly around movements and protests. The current political atmosphere is fuelling new songs and performances across the country. The form is evolving. Today, Yalgaar’s performers sing in both Marathi and Hindi, write new songs and carry the tradition into contemporary contexts. “It is not

something frozen,” he emphasises. Its subjects change because the society around it changes. That evolution also led to the Nirmik Cultural Centre, registered as a society in 2021 by some of Yalgaar’s members. If Yalgaar is primarily a cultural movement and performing collective, Nirmik is an attempt to create a permanent infrastructure: a space for rehearsals, readings, workshops, research, and training. Dhammarakshit says there is no shortage of cultural spaces for some ideological traditions, but Ambedkarite and Dalit-Bahujan artistes often struggle to find places to rehearse, meet and create. “We understand the need for structural work as well. We need dedicated spaces.” Access remains a challenge. Permissions can be difficult when the work is perceived as “political”, and the group is conscious of being watched. Dhammarakshit is reluctant to let that halt his work. Perhaps that is why the Basavanagudi evening felt significant. In a small room, while it rained outside, centuries-old songs just flowed freely. For Dhammarakshit, music is not about telling an audience what to think. It is about leaving something behind, “small seeds” in people’s minds that might make them pause, question their own positions, and perhaps see another person differently.

CULTUREBRIEFS

Vocal and instrumental

Madhuradhvani has organised the following events at Arkay Convention Center, Mylapore. Details: September 6: Thrivengadu Jayaraman’s 93rd birth anniversary concerts by N. Madhan (5 p.m.) and 6.30 p.m.: Mudicondan Ramesh and Sowmya (veena). September 7, 6 p.m.: Renu Meera’s ‘Kadaigalai Arivom, Aaraaivom’; 6.30 p.m.: ‘Madham Thorum Maha Kavi’ a talk by Isai Kavi Ramanan. September 8, 6.15 p.m.: V.K. Manimaran. September 10, 6.15 p.m.: Srimushnam Rajarao and Senkottai Harihara Subramanian (vocal).



Musical celebration

A special musical tribute titled ‘Gana Mukundhapriya’ will be presented as part of the Dikshitar 250 celebrations on September 8, 6.30 p.m., at Bharatiya Vidya Bhavan mini hall, II Floor, Mylapore. The evening, to be hosted by Gana Mukundhapriya, will feature Prof. S. Venkateswaran’s vocal concert with Usha Rajagopalan (violin), Madipakkam P. Suresh (mridangam), Madipakkam A. Murali (ghatam), Madipakkam A. Gopalakrishnan (kanjira) and R. Raman (morsing).

Bharatanatyam solo

The Music Academy will feature Pallavi Anand’s solo Bharatanatyam performance, as part of HCL Concerts, today, 6 p.m., at the Kasturi Srinivasan Hall.



Tribute to Bharati

Natyarangam, the dance wing of Narada Gana Sabha, will present Kanavu Meippada Vendum, a dance performance on September 6, 6 p.m. at is main hall. Dancers Arun Velayudhan, K. Jayalakshmi, Mayura Balagurunathan and Vaishnavi Srinivasan will perform. Carnatic vocalist Bharat Sundar has composed music for this production, which is being organised under the Saroja Vaidyanathan Endowment. The performance is a tribute to Tamil poet Subramania Bharati whose death anniversary falls on September 11. Isaikkavi Ramanan is the resource person.

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06.09.2026
Kannan in the words of the Azhwars

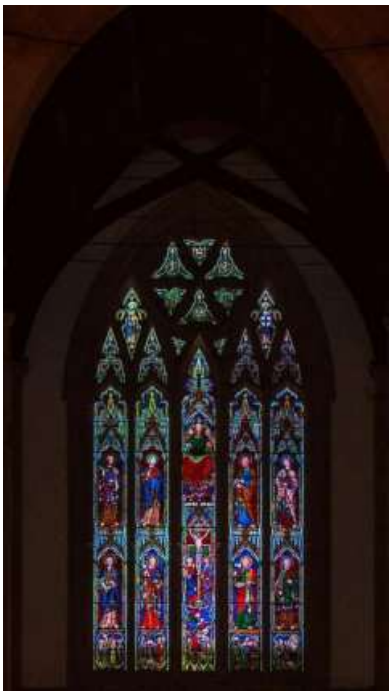
07.09.2026
Gitacharya in the actions of the Acharyas

Time: 6:30 PM onwards
Venue: YGP Auditorium – PSBB School,
Thirumalai Pillai Road, T. Nagar, Chennai – 17.

All are welcome.



Gothic glow Inside Mumbai’s Afghan Church, before and after the light projection
PHOTOS: COURTESY: UJJWAL PURI & SPECIAL ARRANGEMENT



warm tones such as red and gold. Light travelled across the arches and columns, while the stained glass caught and altered the colours projected around it. The church retained its character throughout, but the changing light made familiar details appear briefly unfamiliar. That balance was deliberate. “The theme, motifs and animation are carefully developed to ensure they complement the architecture without altering its character. The animation is designed to flow gently through these details, allowing the space to remain the anchor,” says Rahul Singh Yadav, creative director at FCC.

The restraint is important in a building that is still an active place of worship. Instead of filling every surface with movement, the show, at times, highlighted a single arch or ceiling. The pauses between the dramatic passages gave the audience ample time to appreciate the architecture.

Creating that effect required more than just pointing the projectors at the walls. FCC first surveyed the church to create multiple digital masks to map the artwork onto its uneven surfaces. Between 15 and 20 high-resolution, high-lumen projectors were required for a space of this scale, while installation and calibration took three days.

Working with the stained glass came with its own challenges as glass typically lets light pass through rather than reflecting it back. “We leveraged the colour, texture and thickness of the iconic stained glasses to integrate them seamlessly into the overall experience,” shares Rahul.

The show itself followed a simple



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RAHUL SINGH YADAV

idea: a journey from Earth towards the cosmos. Clouds, stars and drifting light gradually filled the interior, suggesting movement beyond the physical boundaries of the church. “The experience invites the viewer to question where the journey truly takes place. Was it an inward journey or one into the universe,” explains Rahul. What added to the immersive aspect was that the audience was standing inside the architecture rather than watching a projection on a facade. FCC has previously worked on the exteriors of several Mumbai heritage structures. Indoors, the viewer is relatively stationary, allowing the projections to unfold around them. “The indoor-shows are usually more immersive because the experience has to make the viewer feel like they are part of it.”

Projection mapping, inside heritage buildings, is hardly a new phenomenon. Mumbai is catching up to something cities abroad have been doing for years. AURA, launched inside Paris’s Notre-Dame in 2017, uses dozens of projectors and lights to turn the basilica’s interior into an immersive light show. Since then, it has drawn over two million visitors and expanded to cathedrals in San Francisco and the Dôme des Invalides in Paris. Luminescence, a similar immersive touring light-and-sound show, popular across cathedrals in Europe, made its American debut this year inside a basilica in Philadelphia.

For the Afghan Church project, FCC follows the company’s earlier work at the David Sassoon Library, and later interventions at the CSMVS Museum and Rajabai Clock Tower. The larger ambition, Rahul says, is to make residents relate to buildings they walk past without a second glance. “Mumbai has a rich architectural legacy, ranging from old forts and wadas to magnificent Gothic buildings. People walk by without really stopping to look at them. We wanted to create a pause. If art and technology can bring people closer to their own milieu and the structures; it can create interesting pathways for how we experience and value our heritage.”

Lighting up a landmark

How projection mapping is recasting Mumbai’s heritage

Nivedita Javaram Pawar

For 15 minutes, the Afghan Church in Colaba, was transformed – its Gothic arches, vaulted ceiling and stained-glass windows became a canvas for stars, clouds and lights. At

times, the projections receded into the church’s depths; at others, they traced the lines of an arch or climbed towards the ceiling.

Ascension, a projection mapping installation by Floating Canvas Company (FCC), was presented inside the church (August 27 to 29) as part of the Mumbai Light Festival.

It was the company’s first projection mapping project inside a Grade I heritage structure in Mumbai.

The effect was most striking when the projection worked with the architecture rather than overpowering it. The sequence moved through deep blues and celestial imagery before shifting to

CULTUREBRIEFS

Special line up for Gokulashtami

Mudhra presents the third edition of its annual flute concert series ‘Venuganam’, until September 6. Organised as part of gokulashtami, the five-day festival streams flute recitals by established and young musicians on www.paalamtv.com. Time: 6.30 p.m. Concerts to be featured from September 4 to 6 are: Today: Sai Narasimhan with Usha Rajagopalan on the violin, Melakaveri Balaji on the mridangam and Alathur T. Rajaganesh on the kanjira. Tomorrow: R. Athul Kumar with Bombay R. Madhavan (violin), Neyveli K.V. Ramkumar (mridangam) and S. Hariharasubramaniam (ghatam). September 6: Amith Nadig with M.A. Krishnaswamy (violin), Tumkur B. Ravishankar (mridangam) and G. Guru Prasanna (kanjira).

Sri Thyaga Brahma Gana Sabha will feature namasankritanam (4.30 p.m) followed by vocal concert (6.30 p.m.) at Vani Mahal, T. Nagar. Details: September 4: Students of PSBB School, Nungambakkam followed by Chinmaya Sisters. September 5: Students of Sree Vidyavane Sangeetha Vidyalaya and R. Suryaprakash’s concert. September 6: Rajeevi Ganesh (namasankirtanam) and Amritha Murali (vocal). September 7: Students of Sandipani Vidyalaya (namasankirtanam) and Padmashree Srinivasan (vocal). September 8: DAV School students (namasankirtanam) followed by Sruthi S. Bhat (vocal). September 9: Students of Sri Sankara Senior Secondary School, Adyar, followed by Prapancham Balachandran’s flute recital. September 10: Thillaisthanam Sisters’ namasankiratanam will be followed by Vadasithur Sisters’ vocal performance.

Chennai Fine Arts, in collaboration with ShriLa Prabhupada’s Hare Krishna Movement, Chennai, and Kala Madhuryam, will present Sarathi Sangeetotsavam 2026 today at Dakshina Dwaraka, Valmiki Nagar, Tiruvannamur. The following is the list of music concerts to be featured on the occasion. Details: Today: Vocal recital by Kalpalathika Ravishankar (4.30 p.m.) accompanied by Melakaveri Thiagarajan (violin) and Madurai Karthik (mridangam). This will be followed by vocal performances by the students of Sowparnika Sangeetha Vidyalayam, Chromepet at 5.45 p.m., with Shreya Anil on the violin, Madhav on the harmonium and Sooraj TR on the mridangam. The evening concludes with Iyer Sisters’ vocal concert at 7 p.m. They will be accompanied by Palghat G. Kailasapathy on the violin and Umayalpuram V Kalyanaraman on the mridangam.

Bhartiya Sangeet Sadan and India International Centre jointly presents a thematic performance ‘Ram-Shyam’ by dancer Uma Sharma and her students, through Kathak and Brij-Raas style, today, 6.30 p.m. at the Max Mueller Marg, New Delhi. Choreographed by Uma, the evening brings together classical dance and music, to present the timeless leelas associated with Krishna and Rama. The production has music composed by Pt. Jwala Prasad.



Fusion tracks (Clockwise from left) Utsav Lal; fiddle player Winifred Horan and flautist-saxophonist Sam Comerford. PHOTOS COURTESY: ARTISTE’S WEBSITE AND SPECIAL ARRANGEMENT



Bridging two worlds

Ahead of his Ragas to Reels India tour, pianist Utsav Lal reflects on forging a connection between dhrupad and the piano

Narendra Kusnur

Dhrupad and piano. It may sound like an unlikely combination, but Utsav Lal has forged a strong connection between the two. He never viewed the piano merely as a Western instrument, but as a medium through which to explore the melodic and improvisatory possibilities of dhrupad. In the process, he earned the moniker ‘raga pianist’. His musical world extends far beyond Indian classical traditions, drawing inspiration from jazz pioneers Thelonious Monk and Cecil Taylor, Ethiopian pianist Tsegué-Maryam Guebrou and the avant-garde band, The Necks.

One of Utsav’s pet projects is the Indo-Irish collaboration – Utsav Lal’s Ragas to Reels – which returns to India for a four-city tour. He will be joined by the fiddle player Winifred Horan, flautist-saxophonist Sam Comerford and tabla artiste Zuheb Ahmed Khan across six shows.

After performing at Mumbai’s Nita Mukesh Ambani Cultural Centre and ITC Grand Maratha (September 6 and 7), they

will head to Sheraton, New Delhi (September 8, followed by a show at the Bengaluru International Centre (September 9) and ITC Grand Chola, Chennai (September 10). The tour will conclude at Piano Man in New Delhi on September 13.

“Ragas to Reels is a project close to my heart because of my deep connection with Ireland, where I spent much of my teenage years,” says Utsav. “I first presented in 2008 with Sam Comerford and the collaboration has since evolved over multiple editions across Ireland, England, India and the U.S. It continues to take on different forms, with a rotating ensemble of musicians.”

Utsav says, “It’s been a while since I last planned an extensive tour of India. When we were looking at possibilities, *Ragas to Reels* seemed to fit beautifully within the cultural showcase plans of the Embassy of Ireland in New Delhi. I’ve known and played with Winifred Horan for a decade now, though, I knew and loved her music way before that.”

Winifred and Sam joined Utsav for the premiere run of *Ragas to Reels* in New York. “It feels special to have them with us in India along with Zuheb who I’ve been



playing with for over a decade too,” beams the pianist.

Utsav, who is now based in New York, has fond memories of his earlier tours in India with *Ragas to Reels*. “We had an overwhelming response both in 2011 and 2014. We were a smaller ensemble then and adding Winifred gives us a whole new perspective. An absolute core memory from the last trip was visiting the legendary Pt. Hariprasad Chaurasia. Sam gifted him an Irish Low Whistle, which Hari ji was curious about and

gifted Sam a bansuri too.”

Utsav’s piano journey is interesting too. He started by playing old film songs. “I was very young and learnt from the well-known Brian Silas in Delhi. It was useful as I learnt how to play by ear. I also learnt that the Hindi film composers wrote songs based on ragas. While keeping the integrity of the raga, they would orchestrate the string and horn sections and use Latin percussion at the same time. It’s a great example of musical fusion.”

That exposure, says Utsav, ignited a curiosity in him about Indian classical music. Simultaneously, he learnt western classical music, which he continued when his family shifted to Ireland. Later, he began learning dhrupad from Wasifuddin Dagar. He says, “Dhrupad involves a lot of patience and restraint, which helped me in my piano. I also learnt from violinist Sharat Chandra Srivastava and basics of khayal and intonation from US-based vocalist Warren Senders.”

Utsav points out that riyaz is the biggest portion of any day. “The journey and validation is in the practice. Most of my time is spent digging deeper into ragas. . I also spend time improvising, composing, transcribing music, collaborating with friends and peers and learning music from other traditions and places. Huge part of riyaz, for me, is also thinking about why we play music, what I hope to communicate through my work and how it interacts with the world around us. Ultimately, it ends up being a journey of self-exploration through music.”